and M V Ramamurthy. Professor Kothandaraman taught heat transfer, and was in charge of the laboratory which went on to become the workshop of many great beginnings.

Prof. V Subbaraman, head of the department of mechanical engineering who taught me applied thermodynamics, was a man of fairness. When another professor, who had an unexplained dislike for me, gave me very low marks in an internal, it was Prof. Subbaraman who intervened and set right the anomaly. While facing problems at my first job, I had contacted Prof. Subbaraman who asked me to stay put. Engineering college projects are usually done piece meal: one student does the design, another fabricates, and a third tests. Prof. Kothandaraman wanted each student to do a complete project, from scrap to functional testing. Prof. Kothandaraman taught me to say 'it's possible'. And that was something I repeatedly said as a rocket scientist years later, while developing the Vikas rocket engine, and later as the head of the cryogenics project.

Prof. Meiyappan, who taught applied mechanics, and Prof. Maria Loius who handled electrical engineering were equally brilliant, but contrasting in their decibels. Prof. Meiyappan would have the class in rapt attention with his thundering voice; Prof. Louis virtually whispered, making us strain our ears to get the equations right. At the end of the year, the teacher surprised us speaking loud. 'You know, I have a loud voice,' he said. 'But I kept talking in a low tone because I wanted you to concentrate more on what I was saying.'

Prof. Krishnan was a no-nonsense teacher of mathematics. Having taken the day's attendance, he would say, 'Now, whoever wants to leave may please do so; only those who want to learn, stay here'. And towards the end of the year, he would tell those few students who had the courage to leave his class, 'You have bunked enough to flunk the exams, but I assure you if you attend the class at least from now, you will go out of this campus with an engineering degree.' None left the class thereafter.

Prof. M V Ramamurthy approached the most convoluted of problems in the jolliest manner possible—and made learning a pleasure for us. Prof. Kothandaraman took all kinds of questions—including those on unsolvable